The need for multiple tactics reflects the complexity of the populist threat. IOs often face resistance from multiple populist leaders and must adapt their strategies to suit different contexts. Internal dynamics within IOs also contribute to this variability, as staff, leadership, and nonpopulist member states may have differing priorities and preferred tactics. For example, the IMF has simultaneously provided favorable terms to populists, increased its independence from populist states, and launched public campaigns to build support among domestic audiences, as we explore in subsequent chapters.

While IOs possess a robust defensive toolkit, their ability to employ specific strategies depends on context. Appeasement may be less viable if IOs lack desirable resources to offer or if populist demands conflict with core organizational functions. Similarly, sidelining strategies are more effective when IOs have alternative sources of funding, expertise, or information available to them. Factors like organizational size, funding, and visibility also shape IO responses. Larger, well-resourced IOs have more tools at their disposal, while smaller organizations may struggle to adapt. Visible IOs, such as the WHO during the COVID-19 pandemic or the IMF during economic crises, can more effectively appeal to domestic populations, while less prominent organizations may find it harder to influence public opinion given limited public awareness. These scope conditions are discussed further in the following chapter. We do not test the circumstances under which IOs employ one strategy as compared with another; instead, we expect that IOs employ each method to some degree in order to combat populism. We highlight the general prevalence of each tactic as an essential part of IOs' multilateral toolkit.

1.6 Downstream Consequences

While IOs seek to defend themselves in order to endure populists' attacks, their actions can have far-reaching consequences, reshaping their power, agency, transparency, and legitimacy—and even influencing the trajectory of populism itself. While our analysis primarily focuses on how IOs utilize various defensive strategies, we also consider such implications for global governance. Drawing on existing literature and concrete examples, we